This aromatic, mussel soup comes from France's Atlantic coast. You can prepare it ahead, but be sure to reheat the mussels gently, or they will overcook.

mouclade

SERVES 4 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 30 MINS **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

3lb 3oz (1.5kg) small fresh mussels, well scrubbed and washed
2¼ tbsp butter
1 large shallot, finely chopped
1½ cups dry white wine
several sprigs of flat-leaf parsley
¼ small fennel bulb, chopped
1 bay leaf
sea salt and freshly ground black pepper
pinch of cayenne
1 large egg yolk
5 tbsp sour cream or crème fraîche
1 large garlic clove, crushed
½ tsp mild paprika or 1 tsp mild curry powder
a few strands of saffron or ¼ tsp ground saffron
fresh warm bread, to serve

1 Place a large sauté pan over medium heat. Add in the mussels with 1 tbsp of the butter, the shallot, wine, and 1½ cups water. Add the parsley, fennel, and bay leaf, season lightly with salt and pepper, and add the cayenne. Increase the heat and bring to a boil. Cover and cook the mussels for 4–5 minutes, or until they open, shaking the pan a few times.

2 Using a slotted spoon, lift out the mussels and put in a bowl. Discard any that haven't opened and set aside the rest. Strain the liquor through a muslin-lined sieve into a bowl and set aside. In a small bowl, mix the egg yolk with the sour cream until smooth. In a separate bowl, using a fork, mash the remaining butter with the garlic, paprika, and saffron.

3 Shell the mussels, keeping 12 in their shells, and moisten them all with a little of the cooking liquid. Keep warm.

4 Place a large pan over a low heat. Add the butter and, when it bubbles, pour in the mussel liquor, stir, and bring to a simmer. Remove 3 tbsp and whisk it into the egg mixture, then whisk this back into the pan and stir until hot and blended. Adjust the seasoning and divide the mussels between 4 warm bowls. Pour the broth over and serve with the bread.